subject, not to extol their superiority but simply for the record.

In all these areas I have set out to counter what I consider to be bogus history – in Trumpian language, ‘alternative facts’ – by offering what I believe to be a more reasoned alternative. But at the end of the day it is up to you, dear reader, to judge for yourself whether what I have written is any more valid. Here you might like to consider the wise words of one of India’s most distinguished contemporary historians. ‘Remember, of course, to be very cynical,’ declared Professor Romila Thapar in a speech made to fellow academics back in 1999. ‘All historians when they put out theories have an axe to grind and have a political message. So always ask yourself, what is the political message of this historian that you might be reading?’[6]